

Intro to Human Sciences (HS8.102)

QUIZ ONE

ANSWER KEY

History Module SECTION A

Section I

(Answer ALL questions. 120–150 words each. 5 marks each.)

Marking Rubric for SECTION I

- Everything answered; reference to readings given; well structured: 4-4.5
- Covers points but lack of readings; not well structured (too short or too long): 2.5-3.5
- Only some points covered; no readings; badly structured: 1-2

Question 1. Describe the change in the definition of historical fact, from a Rankean objective and neutral, to E. H. Carr's interpretation and selection.

Answer Key:

Clear explanation of Rankean view (facts exist outside of human experiences; task of historian to only collect facts, independent of any bias; discover and present facts "as they actually happened," without interpretation; facts were assumed to exist in the world, waiting to be retrieved and archived).

Clear explanation of Carr's view (facts do not speak for themselves; only those events selected and interpreted by historians becomes a historical fact; Selection is unavoidable because the past is infinite; facts are established through questioning, interpretation, and contextualisation; but history is not arbitrary because facts are subject to evidence, corroboration, and disciplined reasoning.)

Overall the answer should tell us about the shift from "facts as neutral givens" to "facts as constructed but accountable."

Marks to be deducted if answer says Carr believes "anything goes", or fails to describe Ranke properly.

Question 2. Why is periodisation both necessary and problematic in the writing of history?

Answer Key:

Periodisation is necessary because the past is vast and unstructured. Historians divide time into periods to make patterns visible and to organise narratives around change. Without periodisation, it would be difficult to identify transitions, continuities, and processes. Periods such as "ancient," "medieval," and "modern" provide analytical clarity and enable

explanation.

However, periodisation is also problematic because these divisions are constructed and often reflect specific perspectives, regions, or bias. For example, European period categories do not always fit Indian or other non-European histories. Periods may exaggerate, or rupture processes, or conceal historical continuity. They also carry implicit value judgments, such as associating “ancient” with golden age, “medieval” with backward/dark ages, and “modern” with progress. Periodisation is both indispensable and provisional: it is a tool that must be justified and adapted rather than accepted as natural.

Marks to be deducted if periodisation treated as purely false, or if periodisation necessity is not explained.

Question 3. In what ways has the colonial understanding of Indian history continued in present times?

Answer Key:

One, colonial historiography framed Indian history through “Hindu,” “Muslim,” “British,” categories which were separate; Periods based on religion of rulers; Emphasised religion, caste, language is main axis of Indian history; saw India in terms of oriental despotism and unchanging village communities; British civilised backward people.

These frameworks continue in present debates in several ways. Religious Periodisation of history; religion of rulers central to interpretation; View India's geography and time through colonial records and categories; colonial emphasis on enumeration, classification, and community identities has influenced contemporary understandings of caste, tribe, and religion; Even critique of colonial narratives, often work within structures of knowledge first established by the colonial state.

Marks to be deducted for purely moral condemnation without analysis; for only colonial explanation with no connect to present.

Question 4. How has geography shaped historical processes in India?

Answer Key:

Geography has shaped Indian history by structuring patterns of settlement, trade, agriculture, and political power. River basins were hosts to sedentary agriculture and sedentary life; Gangetic basin was the most fertile flat basin which provided resources/surplus for massive empires; mountains and forests were in conflict and complementary to agricultural fields of river valleys. India's regional diversity, is mapped to its geographical diversity.

Monsoon cycles shaped agricultural rhythms and revenue systems. Geography did not determine history mechanically, but it provided enabling and limiting conditions within

which historical processes unfolded. Examples of forests of the ganga valley, of deserts on the indus river, of deccan mountains and Himalayas should be given.

Extra marks for those who talk of geographical phenomena like ganges plains as human artefact.

Deduct marks for those who list geographical phenomena without any explanation.

Section II

(Answer ONE question. 350–400 words. 20 marks.)

Question 5. If facts and historical periods are created by historians, how can they be dependable units for historical narratives? (Discuss this statement by bringing together the lectures on historical facts and historical time; and the readings of EH Carr, Sherlock Holmes, and Romila Thapar.)

Answer Key:

A strong answer should include: 1. **The Apparent Paradox:** If facts and periods are constructed, are they arbitrary? (Reference Carr's critique of naive fact-is-all idea); 2. **Facts as Constructed but Accountable:** Selection from infinite past; Role of questioning; Corroboration and evidence; Sherlock Holmes analogy: inference from clues, not invention. 3. **Periodisation as Analytical Tool:** Necessary for organising time; Based on identifiable patterns; Subject to revision; regionally grounded. 4. **Dependability Through Method:** Critique evidence, ask for corroboration; verifiability and falsifiability; Chronology; Causality; Historians cross check each other. 5. **Romila Thapar** (additional marks for those who reference this): Same event seen/recorded differently by historians based on where and when they were writing; for whom/what purpose they were writing; what we can say; what we can surmise; what we remain unsure of.

Overall should have this to say: Dependability of facts and periods lies not in neutrality but in disciplined procedure. Historical units are reliable because they are open to scrutiny, revision, and evidence-based debate.

Marking rubric:

- Explaining paradox clearly; good use of Carr and Holmes to explain facts; Explains periodisation carefully; has read Romila Thapar: 15-17.5
- Explains paradox; answer mainly from slides with little use of Carr or Holmes; Periodisation half explained; not read Romila Thapar: 11-14
- Only some parts of answer given; only from slides with no readings; confused about facts and/or periodisation: 7-10.
- Haphazard answer; patchy references to some topics: 3-6.

Question 6. If British India was the first data driven State, discuss how new facts can be developed to study processes and milestones of Indian history? (Draw on lectures on History in India; and the readings of Carr, Sherlock Holmes, and Bernard Cohn)

Answer Key:

Strong answer should include: 1. **Colonial State as Enumerative:** Census, surveys, mapping (Cohn); Data production as governance; 2. **Facts as Produced, Not Given:** Carr: facts emerge from questions asked, perspective (GTS, Census, etc); Data requires interpretation (how British Interpreted India through categories of data); 3. **Developing New Facts:** Re-reading colonial archives without colonial categories; Using quantitative and qualitative sources; Combining official records with subaltern sources; 4. **Sherlock Holmes Analogy:** Clues in bureaucratic documents; Absences in records; New clues from new ways of looking at same space/time; 5. **Processes vs Milestones:** Moving beyond events to structural change; Using data to study long-term transformations.

Overall the answer should state: Colonial rule created new facts when they collected new data in the form of census and maps. They imposed new categories; new technologies allowed new evidence to emerge. We can move beyond the categories and rubrics created by colonial knowledge to find new facts in the very data they generated; and also generate new facts from the same sources through new categories. New facts emerge when historians reinterpret old data with new questions.

Marking Rubric:

- Explains colonial data collection as an new idea/technology/perspective with census and GTS as examples; underlines what is new in these facts; integrated Carr and Cohn reading; Examples of how new facts emerge from India; Good structure and clarity of argument: 15-17.5
- Explains census and GTS; Some attempt to link Carr but mainly from slides; No / negligible evidence of how new facts can emerge for Indian history: 11-14
- Only some parts of answer given; only slides with no readings; confused about census, GTS, etc: 7-10
- Haphazard answer; patchy links to some topics: 3-6.